THE FIRANGIS AND THE SALT SEA

If elephants had been one of the major attractions of Malwa and Gondwana for the Mughals, then in Gujarat it was something much smaller and a great deal more intangible—indigo dye. This precious and valuable product was exported in its raw form, and was also used to colour locally produced textiles—velvet, brocades, and cotton— with the extremely sought after and distinctive deep blue colour.

It was not only indigo and textiles, which brought wealth to the province, it was also locally produced high quality weapons (swords, daggers, bows, and arrows), perfumes, mother of pearl articles, and boats, which were constructed in Sarkhej, near Ahmedabad. Merchandise was loaded onto small vessels in the port of Ghogha and sailed down the Gulf of Khambhat* where it was transferred to large ships off the town of Cambay, bound for Turkey and Iraq; Gujarati block-printed textiles were exported to Egypt. With exports bringing in revenue, the sultans were able to import silver and war horses. All this had been accomplished through the rule of the sultans of Gujarat, who had secured land routes from the coast to the rich agricultural hinterlands.

In July 1572, Akbar set off for Gujarat himself, accompanied by some of the women of the harem and select noblemen. Raja Birbal and a few other officers were sent to the Punjab to bolster the forces of Husain Quli Khan, a kinsman of Bairam Khan, while the imperial party proceeded, via Sanganer, to hunt cheetahs. ‘He was quite taken with cheetah hunting,’ admitted Abu’l Fazl but this lukewarm assessment does not capture the intense love that the Padshah had for this solitary, elusive animal. He would eventually have a thousand cheetahs in the imperial stables of which fifty ‘khasa’ (special) ones were kept at the court itself. His very favourite cheetah, Samand Malik, was carried in a litter, wore a jewelled collar and was accompanied by its own servants in full livery running alongside the litter while another servant walked in front, beating a large drum. In Sanganer, Akbar was so delighted when an imperial cheetah named Chitranjan leaped across a wide ravine while chasing a deer that it was